

C10 Nonverbal Communication Awareness

Pillar	Communication	Difficulty	Level 1
Time Required	35-45 minutes	Group Size	4-12
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person preferred (remote adaptation critical)
Prerequisites	None	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Misunderstood messages, feeling unheard, disconnection in meetings, nonverbal signals contradicting spoken words

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Research consistently shows that nonverbal signals carry more weight than verbal content. The brain processes body language, facial expressions, and tone in the limbic system (emotional brain) before the neocortex processes the words. When verbal and nonverbal messages conflict, the brain trusts the nonverbal. A manager saying 'I'm interested in your idea' while looking at their phone sends a clear message, and it is not the verbal one.

In hybrid and remote environments, this problem intensifies. Video calls strip most nonverbal information: peripheral vision is gone, micro-expressions are pixelated, and body language below the chest is invisible. Teams that rely on video communication are operating with a fraction of the nonverbal data their brains evolved to use.

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Contradiction Exercise (10 minutes)

Pair up. Person A delivers a positive message ("I'm really excited about this project") while using contradictory nonverbal signals: flat tone, no eye contact, crossed arms. Person B describes what they actually received.

Then reverse: deliver a critical message ("We need to discuss some concerns about the timeline") with warm, open nonverbal signals: eye contact, open posture, gentle tone. Person B describes what they received.

WHAT TO SAY

"Which message did you believe: the words or the body? In both cases, your brain trusted the nonverbal signals over the verbal content. This happens in every conversation, every meeting, every

email you read while imagining the sender's tone. Awareness of this is the starting point."

Phase 2: Self-Assessment (8 minutes)

Each person reflects privately on their own nonverbal defaults:

- What do I do with my body when I'm listening? (lean forward? cross arms? multitask?)
- What does my face do when I disagree? (do I know?)
- What's my default posture in meetings? (open? closed? variable?)
- What nonverbal habits might I have that I'm not aware of?

Then pair up. Each person shares one thing they know about their own nonverbal habits, and their partner adds one observation: "Something I've noticed is..." This is peer feedback at a very low-stakes level.

Phase 3: The Video Call Challenge (10 minutes)

For teams that work remotely or hybrid, this phase is critical.

WHAT TO SAY

"On video calls, we lose most of our nonverbal toolkit. We can't see posture below the shoulders. We can't read the room. Micro-expressions are lost to pixelation. So the nonverbal signals that DO come through carry disproportionate weight: whether your camera is on, whether you're looking at the camera or another screen, whether you react visibly to what someone says."

"What are our biggest nonverbal blind spots on video calls? And what one change could each of us make to improve what our colleagues receive from us on screen?"

Phase 4: One Commitment (5 minutes)

Each person identifies one nonverbal habit to change and one to reinforce. Specific commitments: "I will stop checking my phone when someone is talking to me" or "I will nod more visibly on video calls to show I'm engaged."

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
Cultural differences in nonverbal norms surface	This is valuable, not problematic. "In some cultures, direct eye contact signals confidence. In others, it signals disrespect. On this team, we have different backgrounds and therefore different nonverbal norms. The goal is not to standardise but to understand." Do not impose a single nonverbal standard.
Someone becomes self-	Normalise: "Everyone has unconscious nonverbal patterns. Awareness

conscious about their nonverbal habits	is not a criticism. It's a tool. You don't need to monitor yourself constantly. Just being aware that your body is communicating, whether you intend it to or not, changes how you show up."
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Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
During the session	The contradiction exercise produces genuine surprise Peer observations surface habits people weren't aware of The video call discussion generates practical commitments
Within 1-2 weeks	Someone puts their phone down or closes their laptop when a colleague is speaking Meeting engagement visibly improves (more eye contact, more nodding, fewer distractions) Someone asks "Am I reading this right?" when they notice a nonverbal signal from a colleague
CLOVER ERA data (2-4 weeks)	Communication scores improve 'Feeling heard' indicators increase

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
C2: Listening Circle	Active listening is heavily nonverbal. C2 teaches the listening skill; C10 teaches the physical expression of it.	Complementary
C9: Conflict Communication	Nonverbal escalation (crossed arms, eye-rolling, sighing) often triggers conflict more than words do.	Run C10 before or alongside C9
V9: Cultivating Empathy	Empathic nonverbal signals (nodding, leaning in, mirroring) build connection. C10 teaches the mechanics; V9 teaches the intent.	Complementary